administrative functions. The changes would, however, result in a loss of 900 jobs at the various facilities in the UK.

This announcement came after a four-year prolonged ‘downturn in the UK and European steel industry, where the fall in UK steel demand’ had been ‘steeper than in any other major European economy’. In an interview with the Press Trust of India, Ratan said, ‘The steel company is really suffering because of the downturn in Europe and the UK. All we are trying to do now is to reduce our cost base so that when we come out of that recession we will have a leaner company.’

Despite all of Ratan’s efforts, Soonawala has a different perspective. He says that the chairman was not hands-on with Corus. He was more focused on turning around the fortunes of Jaguar Land Rover, in which he succeeded. Ratan was personally involved in that, even at the micro level. If he had done so with Corus, the story may have been different, Soonawala adds. But how practical would it have been for the chairman of a conglomerate to be involved in the nuts-and-bolts operation of a steel giant?

In 2012, Ratan stepped down as chairman, Tata Sons. Tata Steel Europe posted a loss of £1.2 billion for FY 2012–13. The Tata company, however, was not alone in feeling the heat. For the period 2008–12, ArcelorMittal’s EBITDA declined by 81.44 per cent, and ThyssenKrupp’s by 76.04 per cent.

Corus’s operations were bedevilled by several problems, which made it less competitive. Even the Thai-owned SSI’s effort to turn around the Teesside facility failed. It was shut down and liquidated in 2015 after having operated for nearly a century, rendering a workforce of 1,700 employees jobless.

Ratan, however, continued to insist on trying to streamline the UK operations. ‘Right now, the problem is that the English facilities are underinvested [and] overmanned,’ he said in Washington where he was attending a US Export-Import Bank Conference.

However, Tata Steel decided that if no buyer was found, it would shut down the inefficient facilities. It was losing too much money. *The Telegraph* wrote, ‘Given the state of Tata Steel UK’s finances, it is a wonder the Indian conglomerate kept the operations running for as long as it did.’

In 2016, the book value of Tata Steel’s UK assets had slumped to ‘almost zero’ and the company was losing a million pounds a day. Faced with this reality, in May 2016, Tata Steel Europe sold its Long Products Europe